

Topic 2.4 - Dilemmas in your own classroom

A real classroom situation

Miss Farah teaches Class 10 English in a small private school in Hyderabad. Three weeks before the board examination, a pupil named Ayesha submits an essay that is plainly not her own work. It is fluent in a way Ayesha has never been, and two sentences appear verbatim in a guide book sold outside the school gate.

Miss Farah knows several other things. Ayesha's father died in January. Her results have collapsed since. The school's rule on plagiarism is a zero mark and a report to the head, and the head has told staff that the school's board results this year are "a matter of survival". Ayesha has never done anything like this before.

Every option Miss Farah has costs her something she is obliged to protect. That is what makes this a dilemma rather than a hard decision.

Explanation

What makes a dilemma a dilemma

An ethical dilemma is not a choice between right and wrong. That is a temptation, and while it can be difficult to resist it is not difficult to analyse.

A dilemma is a situation in which two or more things you are genuinely obliged to do cannot both be done. Whatever you choose, you fail an obligation. Ehrich and colleagues (2011) built their model of teacher practice around exactly this: the teacher is caught between competing legitimate claims, typically the individual pupil's interest, the other pupils' interest, the institution's interest and the wider public interest.

This matters practically. If you approach a dilemma expecting to find the option with no cost, you will search for it, fail to find it, and then either freeze or pick the option that is cheapest for you and call it the right one. Accepting at the outset that something will be lost is what makes a reasoned choice possible.

In Miss Farah's case the competing goods are clear once named: honesty in assessment, which she owes every other pupil and the board; and a duty of care to a grieving child who may be in more trouble than the essay suggests. Both are real. Neither cancels the other.

Grading fairness and assessment integrity

Grading dilemmas are the most common kind a teacher meets, because a mark is simultaneously a piece of feedback to one pupil and a public claim relied on by others.

The recurring pressures are worth naming in advance, because they arrive with a plausible justification attached:

- **Sympathy.** A pupil whose circumstances are genuinely terrible submits weak work.
- **Pressure from above.** A school needs results; a head asks for marks to be "looked at again".
- **Relationship.** The pupil is a colleague's child, or a relative, or simply one you like.
- **Consistency drift.** The last ten scripts are marked more harshly, or more kindly, than the first ten, because you are tired.

The principle that resolves most of these is a distinction between **the mark and the response**. The mark is a claim about the work. It is not a reward, not a message of sympathy, and not yours to trade. What you do *besides* the mark is where a teacher's care operates, and it is almost unlimited: time, a second chance where the rules allow one, a conversation with the family, a referral.

Applied to Miss Farah: the essay cannot receive a mark it did not earn, because that mark would be a false claim and other pupils would carry its cost. But "zero and report" is not the whole of what she owes Ayesha either.

The figure above works the case through. **Empathy:** from Ayesha's side, three weeks before the board, a father dead in January, and a guide book on sale at the gate. **Context:** first offence, rule is zero and report, head under results pressure, and a fact Miss Farah does not yet have, which is what else has changed at home. **Reflect:** honesty in assessment against duty of care, with the school's interest in results as a third pressure that is *not* one of her obligations and must be named as such so it can be set aside. **Action:** the mark stands at zero because the work is not Ayesha's; the report is made because the rule is not Miss Farah's to waive privately; and she asks for the pastoral consequence to be handled separately, having first spoken to Ayesha so the girl is not ambushed.

That decision costs something. It is defensible because the cost is borne where it belongs.

Confidentiality, social media and equity

Confidentiality. A pupil tells you something in confidence. The obligation to keep it is real, and it is not absolute. A common and damaging misconception is that confidentiality means never telling anyone anything. In practice a teacher holds information in trust with a known limit: where a pupil is at risk of harm, the obligation to protect overrides the obligation to keep the confidence.

The professional skill is to make the limit known in advance rather than discovering it in the moment. "I will keep what you tell me private unless you are in danger, and if that happens I will tell you before I tell anyone else" is a promise that can be kept. "You can tell me anything" is not.

Social media. Two distinct issues get confused here. The first is your conduct toward pupils in online spaces: private messaging, adding pupils as contacts, photographs. The default is the same as it would be offline, and the reason is the power imbalance from Topic 2.1, which does not weaken because the medium changed.

The second is your own personal account. Trainees often say that what they post privately is nobody's business. As a claim about privacy that is reasonable; as a claim about professional consequence it is simply false. A teacher is an ethical model to pupils who can see them, and the standing of the profession is collective. Posting a photograph of a class, or a complaint about a named pupil,

or material that would make a parent doubt your fairness, has professional consequences whoever owns the account.

Equity. The hardest of the four, because equity dilemmas rarely announce themselves. Treating pupils identically is easy to defend and often produces unequal outcomes: the same homework expectation lands differently on a girl who does housework until nine and a boy with a desk and a lamp. Treating them differently to reach a fairer outcome is right in principle and opens two risks at once, that you patronise a pupil by lowering what you expect of them, and that other pupils see favouritism.

There is no formula. The workable test is whether you could state your reason to the whole class and to the affected pupil's parents without embarrassment. Adjusting the *conditions* for success usually survives that test. Adjusting the *standard* usually does not.

Activity: The dilemma exchange

Work in groups of three.

Each person writes, privately and in five minutes, a short account of a real dilemma they have witnessed or heard about in a school, with names removed. It must be a genuine dilemma: two obligations that cannot both be met.

Pass each account to the person on your left. They work it through the four steps in writing, ending with a specific decision. Pass again. The third person's job is different: they must construct the strongest possible objection to the decision reached.

Return all three to the original writer and discuss. Allow 30 minutes.

If someone's account turns out not to be a dilemma, because one option is simply wrong, that is a useful finding and worth naming as a group.

Check your understanding

1. State the difference between an ethical dilemma and a temptation, and explain why the distinction changes how you should approach it.

(Understand)

2. Explain the distinction between the mark and the response, and apply it to a pupil whose work is weak because of genuine hardship. *(Apply)*
3. Why is "you can tell me anything" a promise a teacher should not make? Rewrite it as one that can be kept. *(Apply)*
4. A trainee says their personal social media account is private and therefore professionally irrelevant. Identify what is correct in that claim and where it fails. *(Analyze)*
5. Give one example of adjusting the conditions for success and one of adjusting the standard, and explain why the first usually survives the public-reason test and the second does not. *(Analyze)*

Summary

A genuine dilemma is a conflict between obligations you actually hold, not between right and wrong. Accepting that something will be lost is what makes reasoned choice possible; searching for the costless option produces paralysis or self-serving rationalisation.

Grading dilemmas turn on separating the mark, which is a claim about the work and cannot be traded, from the response, which is where a teacher's care operates and is nearly unlimited. Confidentiality is real but bounded, and the bound should be stated in advance. Social media carries the classroom's power imbalance into a new medium and does not dissolve it at the boundary of a personal account. Equity dilemmas are hardest because identical treatment is easy to defend and frequently unfair; the working test is whether your reason could be stated openly to the class and to the parents.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- ☐ I can distinguish a genuine dilemma from a simple right-and-wrong choice and explain why it matters.
- ☐ I can name the competing goods in a described case rather than asserting one is obvious.

- ☐ I can apply the mark-and-response distinction to a grading pressure.
- ☐ I can state the limit of confidentiality in a way I could say to a pupil in advance.
- ☐ I can use the public-reason test to judge an equity decision.

Try this at your practicum school

Ask your mentor teacher this question: "What is a decision you have had to make here where whatever you chose, something was lost?"

Listen without proposing a solution. Afterwards write half a page identifying the two obligations that conflicted, which one your mentor prioritised, and what they did to limit the cost of the one they could not honour. That last part is where experienced teachers differ most from trainees, who tend to think the decision ends when the choice is made.

Do not record identifying details of any pupil.

Summative task

Write 450 to 500 words on Miss Farah's case, from the top of this topic.

Reach a decision, defend it, and then argue against yourself.

Your answer must name both competing obligations explicitly, identify which pressure on Miss Farah is *not* one of her obligations and explain why it must be set aside, state a specific course of action, and then set out the strongest case that your decision is wrong before explaining why you still hold it.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Naming the conflict (Understand)	States both obligations accurately and shows why neither cancels the other

Criterion	What a strong response does
Separating pressure from obligation (Apply)	Identifies the school's results pressure as a pressure rather than a duty, and says why that distinction matters
Self-objection (Evaluate)	Constructs the strongest counter-argument rather than a weak one, and answers it without retreating to "it depends"
Specificity	The proposed action is concrete enough that another teacher could carry it out on Monday

Further reading

- Ehrich, L. C., Kimber, M., Millwater, J., & Cranston, N. (2011). Ethical dilemmas: A model to understand teacher practice. *Teachers and Teaching: Theory and Practice*, 17(2), 173-185.
<https://doi.org/10.1080/13540602.2011.539794>
- UNESCO / International Task Force on Teachers (2019). *Global framework of professional teaching standards*.
<https://unesdoc.unesco.org/ark:/48223/pf0000372167>

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback